

Town of Westhampton
Town Hall
1 South Road
Westhampton, MA 01027

Finance Committee Meeting Minutes
Tuesday, April 1, 2014

The meeting convened at 6:45 PM

Present:

Finance Committee Members: Ellice Gonzalez, Jackie Brodeur, Mary Cleary, Maryanne Duggan, Aniko Giordano, Margaret Parsons, Joseph Pipczynski, Celeste Whiting, Edward Zawacki.

Additional Attendees: Cheryl Provost, Administrative Assistant; David Blakesley, Highway Department; John Shaw, Selectboard; Arthur Pichette, Selectboard, James Huston, Selectboard.

1. The meeting convened at 6:50.
2. We reviewed the minutes from our 3/25/14 meeting. We voted to accept the minutes 6-0-2. Two members were absent at the previous meeting and so abstained.
3. Old Business: Reminder to think of possibilities for a new member to fill the vacancy on the Finance Committee. The vacant seat is for one year. The person would need to be nominated at Town Caucus on April 14th.

We reviewed a question about the library budget. We received an updated and corrected library budget on 4/1/14. The librarian wage increase had been calculated on an incorrect number of pay periods. It is now correct.

We have received no updates from Cindy Landers regarding our school budget questions. We considered whether it would be useful and appropriate to contact the School Committee regarding our questions of the teacher salary increase. Ellice will contact Ashleigh Norris, School Committee Chair, to see if she can help find the answer to the question.

We will review each of the department budgets carefully next week so we tabled further questions.

4. 7:00—We met with David Blakesley of the Highway Department. We reviewed the Transfer Station budget.

David explained the following on the Transfer Station budget:

—The landfill attendant is budgeted to receive a \$0.50 per hour raise which will amount to \$5 per week.

—Margie noted that the Hauling and Tipping budget line item seems a little high as we tend to have had some surplus at the end of the year. David noted that since we got a compactor last year, the amount we pay for Hauling and Tipping is going down, but that since this is his first year managing the transfer station budget (it has been moved to be part of his duties) he did not feel comfortable lowering that item until he has a feel for the transfer station budget.

—Ed asked about the price of tire collection and thinks we may be able to lower that cost by disposing of tires for \$0.75 each through Ed's contact.

—Joe reported that he may be able to find a way to do oil recovery for less.

—The Landfill monitoring fees are for testing landfill-area wells twice per year as per the DEP.

—We briefly discussed the need for stickers at the dump since they are thrown away. We learned that they are for tracking the number of bags, convenience of payment and for keeping traffic flowing smoothly through the transfer station.

—The misc supplies line item is for the installation of another light at the transfer station. We have the light fixture. The money allocation is to pay an electrician to install it. This will improve the nighttime lighting at the transfer station.

David reviewed the Highway Department budget.

—He corrected the Professional Development line item. It should read \$500 (includes level-funding plus fees for the required physicals for the Highway Department staff.)

—He corrected the Hyd License item from FY14. It should have read \$120.

—Under Highway Materials and Construction, the only change is the moving of \$2,800 for Line Painting to Hot Mix since we just finished line painting this year and we need more Hot Mix.

—Noted that maintenance of roads does not qualify for Chapter 90 funds.

—Noted that vehicle inspection fees are going up from \$29 to \$32, but this is not reflected in the budget.

—There is no longer a budget item for the FWD repair.

—The Highway Department does maintenance on all the fire vehicles for free.

—Regarding Road Machinery Fuel, we were able to lock in a good rate last year, hoping to lock in a good rate again this year.

—The Snow Removal budget is \$102,000 because you can't keep the roads safe for anything less than that. There is no FEMA money this year since we didn't have any emergency storm situations. This year we spent an additional \$30,000 which will be paid off of next year's budget or any extra money from the end of this year.

—Capital Planning expense for the Highway Department this year is a FWD Dump Truck with Wing and Sander for \$248,000. The current one is from 1997. The town needs one truck that has FWD since there are some roads that can't be plowed otherwise. David has looked into various truck companies that supply this type of vehicle. We would have to go to bid on this, but he noted that the average price is \$248,000. In 1997 we bought a FWD dump truck for \$104,000. This large price increase is due to the emission regulations. Since the regulations are relatively new there have been some problems with the new emissions technology making the purchase of a 7-year extended warranty essential. David would like to have been able to wait to

purchase it until all the kinks regarding emissions had been worked out, but he believes that we can't wait for that as our current truck is too old.

—Looking forward to the next Highway Department capital expense, there will be a need to replace another truck in 2016. That truck would be going from a single axle to a 10-wheeler so it would be close to \$200,000. Maybe we won't need it in 2016, but we'll need it eventually.

—The industry standard is to replace a dump truck every 10 to 15 years, but ours is currently older than that.

—Our garage has been useful as it keeps the vehicles covered and they are able to work on the vehicles in the winter.

5. 7:45—John Shaw explained the Capital Planning budget.

John Shaw noted the following.

—The Capital Planning spreadsheet is very important and should be heavily considered.

—This is our best shot to get a dump truck for the Highway Department because after this year we are looking at a lot of capital expenses. We tried many avenues to cover the cost of the truck. Asked the insurance company to cover it as it makes the town safer, etc. The insurance company said no.

—David White of the Police Department said he may have a \$7000 surplus this year and could use that toward a less-sophisticated radar sign and then he could take that off of the capital budget for FY15.

—David is recommending that HRHS fund one officer to monitor high school traffic and HS emergencies because it is taxing on our departments. The Highway Department sands the HRHS parking lot. The Fire Department responds to HRHS calls. All of it is funded by Westhampton. The Regional District has said that they provide all our town buildings with water for free (it was too expensive for Westhampton to drill wells for each public building, so they are tied into the regional water supply.) This may not be an equal trade.

—There is an emergency management meeting at HRHS on April 14.

6. 8:00—Selectboard

John Shaw reviewed the Selectboard budget. We discussed the following.

—The Selectboard has not voted on this budget yet.

—The wage increase reflect 2.5% unless 2.5% was too little. For those, there is a stipend increase.

—The state requires another unfunded mandate in the form of an Animal Control Officer/Inspector. The current animal inspector (Rick Tracy) does not want to take on this new position and so his stipend will be rolled into the new Animal CO/Inspector line item. This new position will also call for a change in the general bylaws to include a dog-at-large bylaw.

—The Sanitation Inspector line is being rolled into the Health Agent line. We are moving to join the Foothills Health District. We will know by Town Caucus whether we will go with the Foothills Health District (if no one runs for the elected position of Health Agent,

then we will moved to join Foothills). Health Agent will do health inspections and there will be user fees to offset the cost. The Foothills Heath Agent is more expensive, but we will have more availability (all week instead of just Fridays) and more continuity. The fee structure is determined by the Foothills. We previously didn't charge for some things that should have been charged. It is difficult to predict how much of the Foothills costs will be offset by fees at this time. Margie noted that it would be good to have the fee prices available at town meeting because people will want to know.

—IT support: There are currently multiple websites for the town. There is a proposal to bring it all under one roof, but have individual departments be able to change and manage their content. Discussed the total amount noted. The total did not include the time for someone to transfer content from old websites to the new one. How should this be reflected in the budget?

—The budget is difficult this year. Westhampton has three problems—the high school, the elementary school and unfunded state mandates.

—How much of Free Cash should be spent? Margie noted that we used \$122,000 of last year's free cash to support the FY14 budget.

—John wished the Finance Committee good luck. Every year is always the worst budget year yet.

7. The meeting adjourned at 9:05.

Respectfully Submitted by Mary Cleary